



SENEGAL

Capital city: Dakar
Area: 75,749 sq miles (196,190 sq km)
Population: 10,100,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Muslim 90%, traditional beliefs 5%, Christian 5%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 39%
Life expectancy: 52 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 41 per 1,000 people

GAMBIA

Capital city: Banjul
Area: 4,363 sq miles (11,300 sq km)
Population: 1,400,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Muslim 90%, Christian 9%, traditional beliefs 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Dalasi
Adult literacy rate: 38%
Life expectancy: 53 years
People per doctor: 25,000
Televisions: 3 per 1,000 people

SENEGAL

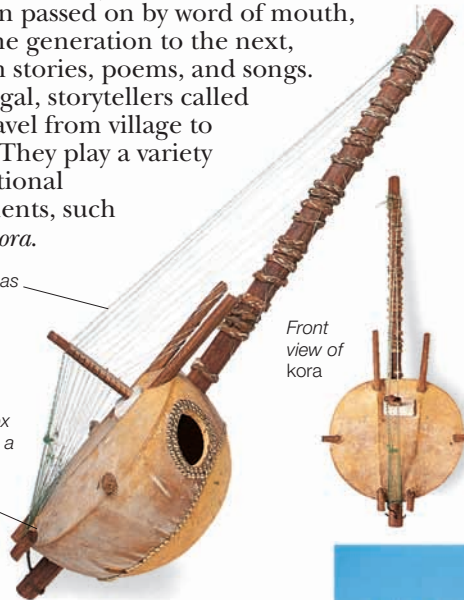
THE MIGHTY SENEGAL RIVER dominates large areas of this country. Every year the river floods, and seasonal crops are grown on the fertile land that the floodwaters leave behind. Senegal is wealthy compared to other countries in this region. It was once an important part of French West Africa, and still maintains close links with France. Among the mix of ethnic groups, such as the Wolof and Mandinke, there are still many French inhabitants. There is a similar mix of religions – Islam exists side-by-side with traditional beliefs. Senegal's beautiful, palm-fringed coastline makes tourism an important economic force here.

MUSICAL STORYTELLING

History is a living thing in West Africa. For centuries, history and other information has been passed on by word of mouth, from one generation to the next, through stories, poems, and songs. In Senegal, storytellers called *griots* travel from village to village. They play a variety of traditional instruments, such as the *kora*.

The kora has 21 strings.

The soundbox is made from a hollowed-out gourd.



Front view of kora



DAKAR

The lively city of Dakar, Senegal's capital, perches on a rocky peninsula that forms the westernmost point of Africa. This major port was once the capital of French West Africa, as can be seen from its grand colonial buildings. Today great poverty is found alongside the expensive restaurants and modern hotels on the streets of Dakar.



FARMING AND FISHING

Nearly three-quarters of Senegal's people work in agriculture. In the north, cereals such as millet and sorghum are the main food crops, and peanuts are a vital cash crop. Rice is common in the wetter southern areas. Peanuts were once grown on nearly half the farmland, but fish is now taking over as the country's main export. A common sight is fishermen setting out in dugout canoes called *pirogues*, made from local trees.

GAMBIA

THE TINY COUNTRY of Gambia is a long, thin sliver of land carved out of Senegal, which surrounds it on three sides. At its widest point, Gambia measures no more than 50 miles (80 km) from north to south. Like Senegal, Gambia has a wide ethnic mix and Islam is very important. Most of the people work in agriculture, relying heavily on the peanut crop. Women play a major role in agricultural life. Rice growing is their main occupation, but near the coast, large areas of swampy rice land have been ruined by the buildup of salt in the soil. Many women now grow vegetables to sell in local markets.



Tourists come for the beaches, but many take trips inland to see the crocodiles, monkeys, and many species of bird that live along the Gambia River.

TOURISM

The tourist industry is the fastest growing part of the Gambian economy. More and more Europeans are coming here to escape cold winters, attracted by the magnificent beaches. Gambia is particularly popular with visitors from the UK, because English is widely spoken in this former British colony. But fears are already mounting that the easy-going local lifestyle will soon be ruined by advancing tourism.

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